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Dear Members of the Search Committee,

I am writing in strong support of Mengnan Xu's application for the Postdoctoral Fellowship at the Centre on Contemporary China and the World. I know Mengnan in two capacities: as her co-supervisor and dissertation committee member at Beijing Normal University, where I hold a position as Professor under China's High-Level Foreign Talents Programme, and as a direct research collaborator. We are co-authors on a paper published in the *Journal of Contemporary China* (2022, SSCI Q1), and through both the supervisory relationship and that collaboration I have had the opportunity to observe her as a scholar across multiple dimensions of her work — from the conceptualisation and execution of independent research to the rigorous development of her doctoral dissertation, which passed blind external review and is scheduled for defense in May 2026. I recommend her with confidence and without qualification.

The paper we co-authored, "Poor and Lazy: Understanding Middle-Class Perceptions of Poverty in China," was Mengnan's project in origin and in execution. The central argument — that middle-class attributions of poverty to laziness and moral failing are not simply ideological prejudice but are shaped by personality traits, socialisation, and faith in state policy — required her to build an original survey instrument, collect data from 2,449 middle-class respondents, and apply binomial and multinomial logistic regression to relate poverty attribution patterns to psychological and sociological predictors. The analysis is technically rigorous, but what struck me most was the intellectual judgment she brought to interpreting the results: she understood from the outset that this was not merely a study of attitudes but a study of the political conditions that make redistributive anti-poverty policy difficult in China. That kind of analytical reach — from empirical patterns to structural implications — is not common at her career stage.

My own research on poverty and shame in China and globally has convinced me that the ideational and the institutional dimensions of anti-poverty governance are inseparable: how the poor are perceived by those not in poverty shapes the political space for policy design as much as any institutional or fiscal variable. Mengnan grasps this. Her paper addresses the ideational conditions under which China's transition from targeted poverty alleviation to relative poverty reduction becomes politically feasible or contested. In doing so, it connects to the largest questions in Chinese political economy: how the party-state manages legitimacy through redistributive commitments, and what the middle class will tolerate. These are questions at the heart of the research agenda that CCCW is built to address.

I should also note what Mengnan represents as a scholar working at an unusual disciplinary intersection. Her quantitative competence is considerable, but it operates in service of questions

that are fundamentally about governance, ideology, and political economy — not simply about methods. The research she has conducted on the organisational ecology of China’s poverty alleviation implementation, and the computational pipelines she has developed to analyse governance documents at scale, extend the analytical logic of our collaborative work into the implementation domain: if the ideational conditions for redistribution shape political feasibility, then the organisational conditions for implementation shape actual outcomes. Taken together, her published work and her dissertation constitute a coherent research programme on China’s anti-poverty governance that is both empirically grounded and theoretically ambitious.

CCCW is a natural institutional home for that programme. The Centre’s focus on Chinese political leadership and governance, its investment in AI-assisted social science, and its position in Hong Kong — at once embedded in and analytically distanced from the mainland governance system — align with what Mengnan has been developing. I am confident that she will make a substantive contribution to the Centre’s research and that the fellowship period will be a productive one for both her and the institution.

In my experience of working with early-career scholars across multiple institutions and countries, Mengnan stands out for the combination of intellectual independence, methodological range, and genuine scholarly ambition she brings to her work. I recommend her to your fellowship without reservation.

Sincerely,

Robert Walker, Ph.D.

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